SUIT ESTABLISHMENT

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

Feel free to disagree with the bidding which is more or less Standard American, not 2-Over-1.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

ESTABLISHMENT LESSON

It's great when you have a suit like A K Q J 10 9, six winners just ready to lead out.
But these suits occur only rarely and then usually in the opponent's hands.
So this lesson is about making winners in suits that are not so robust.
This creating of winners is called "establishing" the suit, or perhaps "setting up" the suit.

Establishing by force:

Sometimes the play will be completely obvious, such as this hand.

The contract is 6NT and West's opening lead is the ♥Q.

♠ K 10 3
♥ K 7 2
♦ Q J 10 9 8
♣ 4 2



♠ A Q 2
♥ A 5 4
♦ K 6 3
♣ A K Q 7

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 3 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 8.

You need 4 more winners, and Dummy's ♦ suit beckons.
Win the ♥ lead, probably with your ♥A, then play ♦K and continue with the ♦ suit until the defense takes their ♦A. That is the only trick you will lose since you can easily reach Dummy's remaining ♦ winners.

Ruffing to establish a suit:

Sometimes Dummy has a long suit which would be useful for discards but you have no high cards in the suit to help establish the suit by force. If you're playing a suit contract you may be able to use ruffs to do the work.

Look at an example of this technique.

The contract is 4♠ and West leads the ♥ A K Q then switches to a trump.

Loser count: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 : Total = 4.

♠ K 4 3
♥ 8 3 2
♦ A K 9 4 2
♣ J 2

Many Declarers will decide the contract depends on the ♣ finesse, so they will pull trumps, get to Dummy and finesse East for the ♣K. And half of the time they will make their contract. Of course the other half of the time they will go down. A more expert Declarer will try to find a plan that doesn't put all her eggs in one basket.



Look at Dummy's ♦ suit. If the defender's ♦s happen to be split 3 - 3 then two winners can be set up by ruffing. But, you have to be careful with your entries. So you win the trump lead in your hand and pull one more trump, making sure you leave the ♠K in Dummy. If the trumps split 3-2 all will be well. If not then you will have to rely on the ♣ finesse. Leave the last trump out for a little while and work on ♦s. Play ♦ A K 2, ruffing the ♦2 with a high trump. IF both defenders follow suit to all three ♦s then the ♦ 9 4 are now winners. Pull the last trump by leading to Dummy's ♠K and discard your ♣ Q 10 on the good ♦s.

♠ A Q J 10 5
♥ J 9 7
♦ 6 3
♣ A Q 10

If it turns out the ♦s do not split 3-3 you will be in dummy with the ♠K and you can take the ♣ finesse.
Played correctly you will make the contract whenever East holds the ♣K but you will also make it when the ♦s split 3-3.
Two chances are definitely better than one.

Ducking to establish a suit:

Here is a nice suit for you and Dummy to have:

♦ A K 9 7 4 2



♦ 6 3

If you are playing a suit contract, say 4♥, you might well establish the suit by ruffing as you did in the last section. But if instead you are playing a notrump contract you will have to establish the suit by a different method.

The "brute force" technique would work just fine with this situation:
The contract is 6NT and West leads the ♠Q.

♠ A 3
♥ 9 3 5
♦ A K 9 7 4 2
♣ A 2



♠ K 8 5 2
♥ A K Q J
♦ 6 3
♣ K 4 3

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

Winner count: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 4 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 : Total = 10.

Needing 2 more winners you will naturally turn to Dummy's ♦ suit. Since there are two black suit Aces in Dummy you don't have a problem with entries so you just bang down the ♦ A K 9. As long as the suit splits 3 - 2 you will establish plenty of extra winners and you will make 6NT with ease.

BUT,

What if Dummy didn't have those two black suit entries???????

The contract is 6NT and West leads the ♠Q.

♠ 3 2
♥ 9 3 2
♦ A K 9 7 4 2
♣ 3 2



♠ A K 8 5
♥ A K Q J
♦ 6 3
♣ A K 4

Winner count: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 4 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 : Total = 10.

You must find 2 more winners and again, the only hope is Dummy's ♦ suit.
If the suit splits 3 - 2 you can establish 3 winners by playing ♦ A K 9. It won't do you any good though, since you will have zero chance of getting to Dummy to use them.

Try this instead. Win the opening lead in your hand and lead a ♦, playing a small one from Dummy. The defenders will win this trick pretty cheaply, but you don't care. You are hoping that their remaining ♦s are now split 2 - 1, in which case they will fall under Dummy's ♦ A K. And best of all, you still have a small ♦ to lead!

This technique, Ducking, is very useful when Dummy is short (or empty) of entries.

20 Deals are worth more than another 1000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **7♣** Goal: at most ____ losers



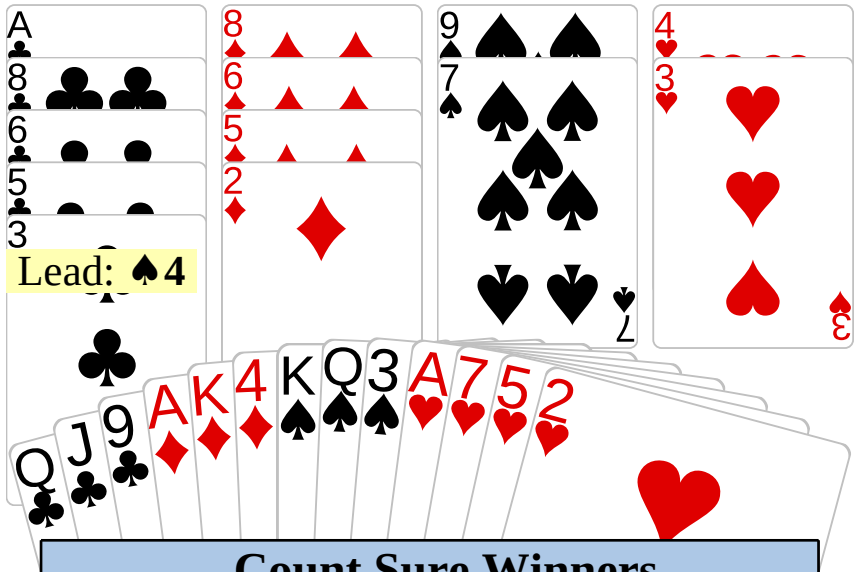
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 5 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least _____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total

Decide How to Develop Winners			
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣K

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 7♣
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠4

Board: 4
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠4

Board: 5
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠2

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ Q
♥ Q 10 9 7 6
♦ A J 3
♣ A 7 4 2

♠ A K 9 7
♥ 4 2
♦ K 10 8 4
♣ 9 6 5



♠ J 10 4
♥ 8 3
♦ Q 9 7 2
♣ K Q J 10

♠ 8 6 5 3 2
♥ A K J 5
♦ 6 5
♣ 8 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♥	Pass	3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♣K

North is to play 4♥. East leads the ♣K, dummy plays the ♣3 and West the ♣5.

West wins the ♠K.

West plays a trump, you follow low and East too.

Dummy leads a ♠ and West plays low.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=3 Total = 6

Obviously you don't really have 6 losers since some of those ♦s and ♣s can be ruffed in dummy. But if you are playing against competent defenders you will only be able to ruff two of them because every time they get the lead they will play a trump. So you must figure on ruffing 2 losers and establishing dummy's fifth ♠ for a discard of the other one.

Win the ♣A and immediately play your ♠Q. The defense will win this trick and probably play a trump. Be sure to win this in dummy and then ruff a ♠ with a high ♥. Now exit with a ♣. They will win and probably play another trump. Win this one in dummy also, breathing a sigh of relief when ♥s split 2-2. Ruff another ♠ with your second-last trump, then play ♦A and concede a ♦.

Whichever minor suit the defense plays next you ruff in dummy, then ruff the fourth ♠, establishing dummy's ♠8 while you still have a trump left in dummy. Dummy is now high.

It took a 2-2 trump split and a 4-3 ♠ split. But that was your best shot.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ Q 10 4 ♥ Q 10 9 6 ♦ 9 3 2 ♣ 7 6 3	
♠ 8 7 5 ♥ K 8 7 5 3 ♦ A K 5 ♣ 10 2	N W E S	♠ A K 2 ♥ A 4 ♦ 8 4 ♣ A K Q J 9 5
	♠ J 9 6 3 ♥ J 2 ♦ Q J 10 7 6 ♣ 8 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2♣	Pass
2♥	Pass	3♣	Pass
3NT	Pass	4NT[1]	Pass
5♦[2]	Pass	5NT[3]	Pass
6♥[4]	Pass	7♣	
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace
3. asks for kings
4. 2 kings

7♣ by East
Lead: ♦Q

East is to play 7♣. South leads the ♦Q.

North plays the ♦2 and you the ♦4.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=0 ♣=0 Total = 1

It should be very clear that the only way to get rid of that ♠ loser is to discard it on dummy's ♥ suit. So after taking the first trick with dummy's ♦A you could pull trumps, then play ♥A, ♥K and ruff a ♥. **IF** the ♥s split 3-3 you could then enter dummy with the ♦K and discard your loser.

The problem is that the ♥s are much more likely to split 4-2, in which case you will need to ruff twice to establish a winner. That means you will need an extra entry to dummy.

That extra entry can only be the ♣10 so you must delay pulling trumps until after you ruff the first ♥. Win the ♦A and immediately play ♥A, ♥K and ruff a ♥ with a high ♣. South discards on this ♥ play. Enter dummy with a trump and ruff another ♥ high. The suit is now established, so you pull trumps, enter dummy one last time with the ♦K and discard that losing ♠ on the good ♥8.

It may have seemed too risky to play ♥s before pulling trumps. In fact, there was no risk at all. If the ♥s were splitting 5-1 then you had absolutely no chance of making the contract.

And if they had split 3-3 this Plan would still have worked.

Board 3
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 3 ♥ 7 5 ♦ A Q 10 6 2 ♣ A K 7 4	
♠ Q 10 6 4 ♥ J 8 2 ♦ K 8 4 ♣ Q 8 3	N W E S	♠ J 9 7 ♥ Q 10 9 6 ♦ J 9 ♣ J 10 6 2
	♠ A K 5 2 ♥ A K 4 3 ♦ 7 5 3 ♣ 9 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♦	Pass	1♥
Pass	2♣	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠4

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠4, dummy plays the ♠3 and East the ♠J.

West plays low.

East wins with the ♦J.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 7

You need two more winners. They cannot possibly come from ♠s, ♥s, or ♣s since one defender must hold at least 4 cards in each of those suits. So your two extra winners must come from the ♦ suit.

There is no reason to hold up on the ♠ since the ♥ and ♣ suits also have just two stoppers. You win the ♠A.

You best play next is to finesse the ♦10. This may gain a trick by virtue of the finesse if West happens to hold the ♦J, but primarily you are working to establish the ♦ suit. Assume East wins the ♦J and returns a ♠.

Again don't hold up. Take the ♠K and lead another small ♦, finessing with dummy's ♦Q. Happily this time the finesse works, and even more happily both defenders follow suit. That means the rest of the ♦s are good and you make an overtrick.

This was just a normal suit-establishment Deal.

If looked different because of the two finesses you took.

Board 4
East Deals
Both Vul

♠ J 10 6 4 2
♥ K J 8
♦ 10 7 3
♣ K 2

♠ K Q 3
♥ A 7 5 2
♦ A K 4
♣ Q J 9



♠ 9 7
♥ 4 3
♦ 8 6 5 2
♣ A 8 6 5 3

♠ A 8 5
♥ Q 10 9 6
♦ Q J 9
♣ 10 7 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		Pass	Pass
1♣	Pass	2♣	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♠4

West is to play 3NT. North leads the ♠4. South puts on the ♠A and returns the ♠8.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 6

Needing three more winners you are going to have to establish the ♣ suit. You are also going to have to be lucky!

You win the second ♠ and play your ♣Q. North covers with the ♣K. What do you do next?

You **DUCK**. If you take the ♣A now you will never get back to dummy to enjoy those other ♣s. So let North have the ♣K. You win his return, (probably a ♠), and play ♣J, then ♣9 to dummy's ♣A. As long as ♣s split 3-2 you will get the three winners you need.

You were prepared to lose that ♣ finesse to South so you could establish the suit in dummy.

North's play of the ♣K may have made you want to jump up with the ♣A, but you must stick to the original play of ducking one trick.

Board 5
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A Q 3 ♥ 6 3 ♦ A K 5 4 ♣ A Q 6 5	
♠ J 9 6 ♥ J 9 2 ♦ Q J 10 ♣ 10 9 3 2	N W E S	♠ K 10 8 2 ♥ K 10 4 ♦ 8 7 2 ♣ K J 7
	♠ 7 5 4 ♥ A Q 8 7 5 ♦ 9 6 3 ♣ 8 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			Pass
Pass	1♦	Pass	1♥
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠2

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠2, dummy plays the ♠4 and West puts on the ♠J.

East plays low.

West wins with the ♥9.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 6

You need three more winners. It is possible your fourth ♦ can be established, but that needs a 3-3 split. It's also possible that the ♣ finesse will work, and also the ♥ finesse. Since you need the ♥ finesse anyway you should go ahead and try to establish the ♥s.

Win the first trick with your ♠Q and play a low ♥, ducking in dummy. West will no doubt win a cheap trick but no matter. When you next gain the lead play your other low ♥ and finesse the ♥Q. Assume this wins (if it doesn't you will be going down for sure). Play the ♥A and if both defenders follow your other 2 ♥s are good and your contract is made.

Ducking the first ♥ and finessing the second could let you wind up with no tricks at all in the ♥ suit.

But, it is your only chance to make the contract.